

TOP of the Charts

The spotlight this month focuses on Pentagram, the first Indian band to top the MP3.com Asia charts

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Pentagram isn't just another Indian rock band. It stands head and shoulders above other Indian rock hopefuls, and one reason for this is that the band members have always done a lot of experimenting with their music and sound. Their most recent achievement has been to bag the top spot in the MP3.com Asia charts.

The band believes that the Internet has a really wide reach as a medium, and MP3.com has served them well in meeting their objective of reaching out to a wider audience rather than just rock enthusiasts. Barely a week after they were uploaded onto the site, all five songs, which were previewed under various genres such as Drum and Bass, Electronica, etc, reached the number one slot in their respective categories. This achievement has made Pentagram the first Indian band to top the MP3.com Asia charts.

Pentagram comprises five members—Shiraz

samplers (one an Akai and the other an SP808), guitars, keyboards and drums.

Pentagram first tasted success with wins in three big competitions, the most prominent being Livewire. This was followed by a record deal with Plus Music leading to the release of the album, *We're Not Listening* in 1996, which became the fastest selling Indian rock album. The band followed this up with two music videos called *The Ignorant One* and *Yoo*, which got good exposure on music channels. MTV's Artist of the Month and the Channel V award for Best Live Band were the next two honours conferred upon the band.

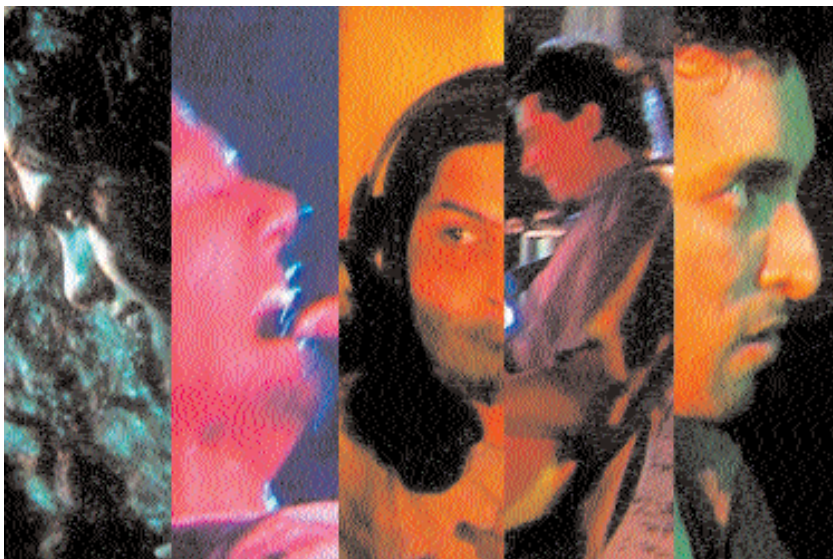
In 1999, Pentagram got involved in a bit of controversy. Their single, *The Price of Bullets* which also featured Javed Akhtar and Shankar Mahadevan, was refused airplay by the music channels. The track was based on the Kargil war, and the video was considered too violent and graphic to be aired. Not to be deterred, the band put the tracks up on the Internet, which led to it being featured in *Rolling Stones* magazine.

Topping the MP3.com Asia charts has now focused even more attention on the group, with a lot of publicity from the media and a number of offers including one from a Russian band that sent them a couple of songs to remix.

"We have decided to focus on the Internet and the computer generation who are a very important aspect for us right now and for the future," says Randolph. The band members also feel that putting up songs on free sites such as MP3.com makes for a good business strategy as it arouses public interest in the album. However, what's more important to the band than being number one on the charts is the number of people that are logging on to the site to listen to the tracks—an average of 50 people a day. And, of course, being the first Indian band to achieve this only adds to the jubilation. "Being the first Indian band to top the charts felt good. Being number one in all of Asia is a good thing."

However, the band members insist that topping the MP3.com Asia charts wasn't all that big a deal. "By 1998 and 1999 we were pretty well known in the country and this has just gotten us into the news again. We had done cassettes and CDs and we just thought that it was time to get some music flowing on the Internet as well, which is why topping the MP3 Asia charts is nice but not such a big thing for us as it is for the fans and people who like our music." ■

"We decided to focus on the Internet and the computer generation, who are very important for us"



Pentagram: Papal (bass), Vishal (vocals), Shiraz (drums), Randolph (guitar), Clyde (effects)

on drums, Vishal on vocals, Clyde on effects, Papal on bass and Randolph on guitar. Shiraz, Clyde and Vishal started the band in 1993, and were joined by the other two in 1994.

They shifted from traditional rock towards progressive alternative pop and electronica in an effort to improve themselves and break the barriers of traditional rock music. The group uses minimal gear to record their songs—a couple of